CORE FALSE BELIEF #6 · MY STRENGTH

“I cannot handle this.”

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Where it often comes from

This belief often appears when stress piles up: illness, caring for a loved one, money problems, grief, or several crises at once. It can also come from growing up without being allowed to face difficulties, or from being overwhelmed as a child with burdens too heavy for a child to carry. The body’s alarm system then fires quickly, and the thought “I can’t handle this” arrives before we have even tried.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not promise that life will be easy, but it does promise that God will not leave us to carry it alone. God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in trouble. He tells His people not to fear, because He will strengthen and uphold them. Paul described being hard pressed but not crushed. Jesus invites the weary to come to Him and find rest. You may not be able to handle this by yourself, but you are not by yourself.

> *“Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness”* (Isaiah 41:10).

Also see

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “No temptation has seized you except what is common to man. And God is faithful; He will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear. But when you are tempted, He will also provide an escape, so that you can stand up under it” (1 Corinthians 10:13).

> “We are hard pressed on all sides, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed” (2 Corinthians 4:8–9).

> “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light” (Matthew 11:28–30).

Common self-statements

- This is too much for me.
- I’m going to fall apart.
- I can’t cope with one more thing.
- Other people could handle this, but not me.
- I need to escape.
- If this goes on, I’ll break.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Imagining the worst possible outcome and assuming I will not survive it.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that I will fall apart before it happens.
- Emotional reasoning: Believing I can’t cope because I feel overwhelmed.
- Discounting the positive: Forgetting the hard things I have already gotten through.

Challenging questions

- What hard things have I already gotten through?
- What is the next small step, not the whole mountain?
- Am I trying to handle tomorrow's problems today?
- What does God promise to those who are overwhelmed?
- Who can help carry part of this load?
- What would I tell a friend in my situation?

Truth summary

> This is hard, and I feel overwhelmed. But I have gotten through hard things before, and God has promised to strengthen and uphold me. I don't have to handle everything at once. I can take the next step, ask for help, and lean on Him.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Troubles
- Hardship
- Strength
- Anxiety/Worry
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
Bring fear and uncertainty to God rather than carrying the outcome alone.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn directs attention to Christ when fear or earthly concerns dominate.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I cannot handle this"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I cannot handle this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What hard things have I already gotten through?
- ☐ What is the next small step?
- ☐ Am I carrying tomorrow's problems today?
- ☐ What does God promise the overwhelmed?
- ☐ Who can share the load?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God will strengthen and help me.
- ☐ I am hard pressed but not crushed.
- ☐ I only need to take the next step.
- ☐ I have survived hard things before.
- ☐ I can share the load.
- ☐ Jesus gives rest to the weary.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ Psalm 46:1
  "God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 4:8–9
  "We are hard pressed on all sides, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] What I got through today: Each evening, write one hard moment from the day and how you got through it, even if it was messy.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Isaiah 41:10 becomes: "James can write: "God is with me. He will strengthen me, help me, and hold me up today.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Troubles" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Break it down. Write the whole situation at the top of a page. Below it, list the smallest next steps. Do only the first one today.
- [ ] Remember past strength. List three hard things you have already survived. Write how God helped you through each one.
- [ ] Ask for one specific help. Ask one person for one concrete thing, such as a meal, a ride, or an hour of company.
- [ ] Practice slowing down. When you feel overwhelmed, stop, breathe slowly for one minute, and pray Isaiah 41:10 aloud.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I cannot handle this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A hard moment I got through
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I cannot handle this.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, this feels like more than I can carry. You promised to strengthen me, help me, and hold me up. Show me the next step, send help where I need it, and give me rest in You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.